

## Is a Business Degree Worth It in the AI Era? The 2026 Risk Score

The free sampler — the score by track, the six factors in brief, and the honest reasons to think twice. The complete profile goes deeper.

7.6

AI EXPOSURE · BUSINESS ANALYST / COORDINATOR  
where 10 is most at risk

Re-scored every six months. We publish where we might be wrong.

**Quick answer:** A business analyst or coordinator role scores **7.6 out of 10** for AI exposure, where 10 is most at risk. General management with real accountability scores **4.9**. Business is the most-taken degree in the country and it points squarely at the exposed end. The protected destinations are real, but the traditional route to them runs through exactly the jobs being automated.

**The short answer for parents: a general business degree with no specialization, no placement and no analytical depth is one of the weaker bets in this index.** The versions that work are specific: strong co-op programs, a specialization with structural protection, genuine quantitative depth, or an explicit route into operations or ownership.

## Business AI risk score by destination

Every career in this index is scored 1–10, where **10 is most exposed** to AI. Same six factors, same weights, applied identically to a manager and a paramedic.

| DESTINATION                        | 2023 | 2025 | FALL 2026  | 3-YR MOVE | BAND          |
|------------------------------------|------|------|------------|-----------|---------------|
| General management / P&L ownership | 4.2  | 4.5  | <b>4.9</b> | +0.7      | Moderate      |
| Supply chain & operations          | 4.3  | 4.6  | <b>5.0</b> | +0.7      | Moderate      |
| HR / people                        | 4.7  | 5.0  | <b>5.3</b> | +0.6      | Moderate      |
| Project management                 | 5.3  | 5.7  | <b>6.1</b> | +0.8      | Moderate–High |
| Business analyst / coordinator     | 6.2  | 7.0  | <b>7.6</b> | +1.4      | High          |

*2023 and 2025 figures are reconstructed using current methodology, not archived from past editions.*

**How that compares:** the median career in this edition scores around 5.5. Bedside nursing scores **2.8**. A service electrician scores **2.5**. Entry-level software development scores **8.1**.

**Note what is missing from this table: anything below 4.9.** Business is the only field we score with no genuinely low-risk destination. Every other profession has a protected core; business has a protected ceiling.

## Will AI replace business analysts?

It is already displacing a substantial share of the work, and unlike most professions there is little structural protection to slow it down.

| AI IS TAKING                              | IT CAN'T TOUCH                                                 |
|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Report building and dashboard maintenance | Owning a number and answering for it                           |
| Deck assembly and formatting              | Managing people                                                |
| Market and competitor research            | Negotiating with someone who has different interests           |
| Process documentation                     | Deciding what should be measured at all                        |
| Requirements gathering and write-up       | Judgment when the data is incomplete and the call is expensive |
| Meeting notes, trackers, status reporting | Being accountable when the quarter misses                      |

The pattern in business is unusually clean: **almost everything on the left is what an entry-level business graduate was hired to do.**

## Why does business score the way it does? The six factors

How a business analyst rates against each. Ratings are 0–10 on each factor's own terms.

| FACTOR                                                            | RATING | EFFECT ON RISK    |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|-------------------|
| How much of this job can AI already do?                           | 8.5    | ↑ severe exposure |
| How hard will it be to land that first job?                       | 7.5    | ↑ severe exposure |
| Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?               | 1.5    | ↓ almost none     |
| Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?    | 4.5    | ↓ weak            |
| Does the law require a licensed human?                            | 1.5    | ↓ none            |
| How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations? | 4.5    | ↓ weak            |

Business has no licensing protection, no physical requirement, and accountability that only arrives with seniority. What protection exists has to be earned rather than inherited from the profession.

#### ONE FACTOR, WORKED THROUGH IN FULL

*So you can see what the analysis actually looks like.*

#### **How hard will it be to land that first job? — rated 7.5, and the mirror image of nursing**

This factor is the clearest illustration in the whole index of why we score entry separately from the job itself.

Compare two professions. Nursing rates **2.0** here — its on-ramp is legally mandated, since a student cannot qualify without supervised clinical hours, and no employer can decide otherwise. Business rates **7.5**, and the difference is not about how useful the work is. It is that nothing protects it.

The classic business first rungs — analyst programs, coordinator roles, junior project management — are precisely the automatable layer. Firms that once hired three graduates to build the reports now hire one experienced person with tooling. Nothing in law or professional regulation prevents that, so nothing has.

**And there is a second pressure our framework does not capture at all.** Business is the most-taken degree in the country, which means entry-level roles face plain oversupply alongside automation. The Federal Reserve Bank of New York puts recent-graduate underemployment at **41.5% — against 12.8% for nursing, the lowest of any major it tracks.** Two forces compressing the same rung, only one of which we measure. We flag this as a limitation rather than pretending the score covers it.

The consequence is specific and it is what makes business harder than its scores suggest. The destination jobs — management, P&L ownership, operations leadership — are genuinely protected at 4.9 to 5.0. But you historically reached them *through* the exposed roles. **The ladder's top is intact. Its bottom is thinning. And nobody has yet built a replacement route.**

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## Which business careers are safest from AI?

Ranked by exposure, safest first:

1. **General management / P&L — 4.9.** Accountability for outcomes and for people is the protection, and it is real. 2. **Supply chain & operations — 5.0.** Leans physical, involves real-world constraints, and has proven stubbornly resistant. 3. **HR / people — 5.3.** Human judgment, conflict, and legal accountability, though administrative HR is heavily exposed. 4. **Project management — 6.1.** Coordination is automatable; accountability for delivery is not. 5. **Business analyst / coordinator — 7.6.** The exposed layer, and the traditional way in.

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## Is a business degree still worth it in 2026?

It depends almost entirely on what version of it you take.

The weak version is a general business degree with no specialization, no placement, and no quantitative depth, pointed at an analyst job. On our scoring that is close to marketing in risk, and it is what a large share of business students are actually enrolled in.

The versions that hold up:

- **Strong co-op or placement programs**, where the experience substitutes for the vanishing analyst rung
- **Operations and supply chain**, which lean physical and score meaningfully better
- **Genuine analytical rigor** — the judgment layer rather than the reporting layer
- **An explicit entrepreneurial track**, since building something is the one business activity that cannot be entry-level-automated

The question worth putting to any business program: **what job title do your graduates hold at year one, and at year five?** The gap between those two answers is the whole story, and most programs have never been asked.

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## Common questions

**Will AI replace business analysts?** It is already displacing much of the work — requirements gathering, documentation, reporting and dashboard maintenance are among the most automatable tasks we score. The role is not disappearing so much as its entry floor is rising.

**Is a business degree useless now?** No, but it is the field where the specific program matters most and the general version matters least. Placement, specialization and analytical depth are what separate the outcomes.

**What is the safest business career?** General management with real P&L accountability, at 4.9, followed by supply chain and operations at 5.0. Both are protected by ownership of outcomes rather than by any structural feature of the profession.

**Is an MBA still worth it?** Our index scores the work rather than the credential, but the pattern is suggestive: the protected destinations are all accountability roles, and an MBA is one of the more direct routes into them. It does not protect the analyst tier below.

**Is business safer than computer science?** At entry, marginally — 7.6 against 8.1, both high. At senior level business management (4.9) and software architecture (5.4) are close. Neither field protects its own entry route.

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## Related profiles

- **Finance** — 8.0 entry analyst, 4.6 advisory
- **Accounting** — 7.9 transactional, 5.2 CPA advisory
- **Marketing & communications** — 8.2 execution, 5.5 strategy
- **Computer science** — 8.1 entry-level, 5.4 senior. Free to read in full.
- **Skilled trades** — 2.5, the comparison most business families never run

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## What's in the full business profile

This sampler tells you where business stands. The full profile tells you what to do about it.

|                                                                              | SAMPLER        | FULL<br>PROFILE |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|-----------------|
| Verdict, all destination scores, 3-year trend                                | ✓              | ✓               |
| Six-factor ratings                                                           | ✓              | ✓               |
| Reasoning behind every factor rating                                         | one<br>example | ✓               |
| How durable each protection is                                               |                | ✓               |
| The entry-path problem in detail — and what still works as a route in        |                | ✓               |
| The honest downsides — oversupply, generalist competition, unclear outcomes  |                | ✓               |
| What's genuinely good about it — and who this work suits                     |                | ✓               |
| The AI-native advantage — how to prepare, and why this cohort has an opening |                | ✓               |
| Specializations that hold up — and the ones that don't                       |                | ✓               |
| Where the degree leads later                                                 |                | ✓               |
| Program evaluation checklist — placement, specialization, outcome data       |                | ✓               |
| Questions to ask a program — plus red flags                                  |                | ✓               |
| Sourced further reading, including the case against our score                |                | ✓               |
| Discussion questions for parent and student                                  |                | ✓               |
| A short version written directly to the student                              |                | ✓               |
| Technical scoring appendix                                                   |                | ✓               |

## GET THE FULL PROFILES

Most families are weighing two or three careers seriously, and a few more they haven't ruled out. Pick the ones you need.

|            |      |                          |
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Each full profile includes everything in the table above, plus a short version written directly to the student and the technical scoring appendix. Spring 2027 updates of whatever you buy are included.

**[Read a complete profile free →](#)** We publish one profile in full, openly, so you can judge the depth before buying anything. Computer science is the one to read — it's the most surprising result in the index.

*Pivotum scores thirty careers against AI exposure using a fixed, published methodology, re-scored every six months. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. We publish where we might be wrong.*